



DIRECTORS

E. G. "Jerry" Gladbach
Dean D. Efstathiou
William C. Cooper
Robert J. DiPrimio
William Pesci
Peter Kavounas
Richard M. Green
Barbara Dore
Thomas P. Campbell
Edward A. Colley
Jacquelyn H. McMillan

GENERAL MANAGER

Dan Masnada

Water Currents

Progress Report on Efforts To Clean Up Well Water Contaminated by Perchlorate

For many years, until about 1987, the Whittaker Corporation made, stored and tested rockets, missiles and practice explosives on about 1,000 acres in the center of the Santa Clarita Valley. Toxins including ammonium perchlorate, an accelerant in rocket fuel, were used in the process and disposed of on the property. Tests have confirmed that perchlorate continues to leach from the soil on the currently vacant property into the groundwater beneath and adjacent to the site.

Concerns for Our Health

Perchlorate dissolves easily in water. It presents health concerns and small quantities may affect the functioning of the thyroid gland. The Office of Environmental Health Hazard Assessment (OEHHA) has proposed a Public Health Goal for the amount of perchlorate in drinking water. OEHHA's proposal suggests a range of two to six parts per billion. However, no Maximum Contaminant Level (MCL) has been established by either the U.S. Environmental Protection Agency or the California Department of Health Services (DHS) for the amount of perchlorate allowed in drinking water. However, DHS has established a provisional limit, called an Action Level, which is four parts per billion.

An Important Water Resource

Several years ago, under the direction of DHS, extensive tests of all local municipal wells were initiated to determine if perchlorate was present in the water. At that time, tests showed no perchlorate in any shallow Alluvial Aquifer wells. However, perchlorate was found in four of 12 wells pumping from the deeper Saugus Aquifer. These four wells were promptly taken out of service and are not currently operated.

Groundwater from the Saugus Aquifer is an important long-term water resource for the Santa Clarita Valley. It is especially valuable during dry years when surface water supplies may be limited. Since conditions in California change from year to year, groundwater supplies from the Saugus Aquifer may be needed at any time and must be promptly restored. The four affected Saugus Aquifer wells have a combined capacity of 9,000 gallons per minute or about 14,500 acre-feet* a year.

AVERAGE/NORMAL-YEAR WATER SUPPLY AND DEMAND ASSESSMENT

<i>Local Supplies</i>	
Saugus Aquifer	8%
Alluvial Aquifer	32%
<i>Imported Supplies</i>	
SWP Entitlement (95,200 afy)	60%

DRY-YEAR WATER SUPPLY AND DEMAND ASSESSMENT

<i>Local Supplies</i>	
Saugus Aquifer	17%
Alluvial Aquifer	40%
<i>Imported Supplies</i>	
SWP Entitlement (95,200 afy)	43%

Progress Report: Perchlorate Clean up

From page 1...

CLWA and Local Water Suppliers File Suit

The years of negotiations between CLWA, local water purveyors and the current owners of the property, Santa Clarita LLC (and its subsidiary, Remediation Financial Incorporated, RFI), in an effort to reach agreement on a cleanup, reached a point of being unproductive. In November 2000 CLWA and local water purveyors filed a lawsuit to compel the various responsible parties to pay for the necessary toxic cleanup.

Both federal and state statutes cover the responsibilities of the various property owners responsible for the pollution. They must implement a regulatory-approved cleanup process of the perchlorate, provide cost recovery and accept liability as to current and future damages.

Bringing the Wells Back Into Service

CLWA and its fellow members of the local water community are developing a plan for a water treatment process to return the four impacted wells to service as soon as possible. The plan includes the possible use of current technology, already in use in other parts of California, most notably in the nearby San Gabriel Valley (La Puente Valley County Water District). This process removes perchlorate and restores the water to safe drinking water quality. Recently the CLWA Board of Directors approved an engineering analysis of all available perchlorate removal technologies to determine which will be the most effective. Costs to build and operate a treatment facility to implement the process are estimated to be in excess of \$100 million.

CLWA and U.S. Army Corps of Engineers Study Groundwater

In April 2002, CLWA entered into a 50/50 cost-sharing agreement with the U.S. Army Corps of Engineers to conduct a phased feasibility study. The study involves sampling, data compilation and analysis of perchlorate-contaminated groundwater from the Whittaker property to provide a thorough evaluation of the contamination. This work complements testing and evaluation of the contamination in the four Saugus wells, being conducted by the local water purveyors.

Col. Richard G. Thompson (left) and CLWA General Manager Dan Masnada at April 2002 ceremony. CLWA and the U.S. Army Corps of Engineers agreed to share costs to conduct a phased feasibility study to evaluate the extent of perchlorate contamination in local groundwater. The COE continues its sampling and analysis.



RECENT ACTIVITY:

Moving Forward to Clean Up Perchlorate Contaminated Soil and Water

- After the U.S. Army Corps of Engineers Cost-Share Agreement was signed in April 2002, the City of Santa Clarita convened a meeting of local elected officials, including members of the CLWA Board, with RFI. Many questions were asked about why RFI had not commenced efforts to clean up both the groundwater and the site. City representatives asked RFI to place money in escrow to fund cleanup efforts. RFI sent a letter to the City describing its past actions and its inability to fund cleanup efforts due to lack of capital.
- During the summer, this meeting evolved into efforts by City and CLWA staff to design a multi-part strategy to address the problems of the former Whittaker site. This strategy included the City hiring special counsel to assist with the effort, much as CLWA had done when it filed its lawsuit.
- In June, RFI announced in the media that it had put the property up for sale.
- At a later elected officials meeting in September, Assemblyman Keith Richman offered to facilitate discussions with the state Department of Toxic Substances Control (DTSC) staff and local interests regarding continuation of an Enforceable Agreement that had been developed for the site in 2001.
- A meeting with DTSC Director Ed Lowry was held in October, and he was given a tour of the Whittaker site.
- Also in October, it was announced that there was a potential buyer for the site, Cherokee Investment Partners, LLC. Its representatives have met with City Council and staff, CLWA and the local water purveyors, and the local Citizens Advisory Group. Meanwhile, it is performing a “due diligence” assessment of the property and the site contamination.
- Assemblyman Richman asked DTSC, CLWA and local water purveyors to meet to discuss possible treatment options to bring the four impacted wells back into service as soon as possible. A meeting was held in late October with DTSC, and hydrology experts working with the water community on the problem provided DTSC staff with additional information.
- The lack of action by Whittaker Corporation to begin cleanup of the site has resulted in an order by DTSC in November informing Whittaker Corporation that it is responsible for the cleanup of the soil and groundwater beneath its abandoned munitions plant.
- In late November 2002 a shallow Alluvial Aquifer well adjacent to the Whittaker property was also found to be contaminated and was closed.
- The Corps of Engineers continues its work on the site, drilling monitoring wells and taking samples. In the meantime, CLWA and the water purveyors are beginning to test the contaminated wells to assist in designing a treatment system.

*The former Whittaker Corporation munitions plant
sits on 1,000 acres in the center of Santa Clarita*

**The rainy season
is here...**

**Have you reset
your sprinkler
timer?**

The shorter days and rainy periods of winter mean that your lawn and garden require much less irrigation. Please be sure to reset your automatic sprinkler timer to reduce water use!

**Remember: Use Water
Wisely—It's a Way of
Life!**

Facts About Perchlorate

WHAT IS PERCHLORATE?

Perchlorate is an inorganic chemical that is used in solid rocket propellants, fireworks and explosives.

WHAT IS THE HUMAN HEALTH CONCERN?

Perchlorate interferes with the ability of the thyroid gland to utilize iodine to produce thyroid hormones. Thyroid hormones are needed for normal prenatal and postnatal growth and development in children, and for normal metabolic function in adults.

HOW DOES THIS AFFECT CALIFORNIANS?

Since 1997, perchlorate has been found to be a drinking water contaminant in about 284 water sources throughout California. (In Los Angeles County, 23 wells have been found to exceed allowable levels of perchlorate and have been taken out of service.) Most of this contamination appears to be the result of historic activities of the aerospace and defense industries.

For more information:

www.dhs.ca.gov/ps/ddwem/chemicals/perchlorate/actionlevel.htm

*An acre-foot is approximately 326,000 gallons of water, and is enough to serve all the water use needs of two households for one year.

♻️ Printed on recycled paper. Each ton of recycled paper saves 7,000 gallons of water.

Your Questions and Comments Are Important To Us

Please call us at 661-297-1600 or email us at mail@clwa.org with questions or comments.

**CASTAIC
LAKE**

27234 BOUQUET CANYON ROAD
SANTA CLARITA, CA 91350-2173
661 297-1600
www.clwa.org

ADDRESS SERVICE REQUESTED

PRSRT STD
U.S. POSTAGE
PAID
SANTA CLARITA, CA
PERMIT NO. 440



**WATER
AGENCY**